



GLACIERS



A glacier is like a huge river of ice that starts its life as a tiny snowflake. As more and more snow falls and builds up, in time it gets squashed under its own weight and turns to ice.

A glacier moves very slowly downhill. Because it is very heavy, it can push rock along like a bulldozer. It can wear away the sides of mountains, smooth off the jagged bits from rocks, and move giant boulders over dozens of miles.



Close-up view

The pilot in this plane is watching a wall of ice break away from a glacier and begin to crash into the water below.

Mountains

Glaciers begin as huge snowfields.

The snow collects in hollows and turns to ice under its own weight.

Glaciers usually move downhill very slowly, no more than a few inches each day.

The ice begins to move and rub away the sides and bottom of the hollow. Little by little, it changes the shape of the land and makes it into a U-shaped valley.



Ice power

When the water in this bottle freezes and turns to ice, it takes up more room and breaks the bottle. When the water that makes up the ice of a glacier freezes, it takes up more room and pushes away the rock.

